



ICPSR 37679

Radicalization on the Internet: Virtual Extremism in the United States, 2015-2017

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User Guide



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Secondary Data Analyst's User Guide

The data in all three STATA files are displayed in rectangular files. The files were collected in sequential years (2015, 2016, 2017). Wave 1 of the data contains 56 questions, Wave 2 contains 49 questions, and Wave 3 contains 56 questions. All three data files contain similar variables; many variables appear in all three data files, although there are significant differences as well. All three datasets contain variables capturing similar sociodemographic information. Likewise, they all contain variables gauging online habits and routines, and interactions and experiences with hateful online content. They also contain variables on online and offline social bonds and trust in various institutions. Waves 2 and 3 contain variables measuring deviant acts perpetrated by respondents, as well as views of deviant acts. Waves 2 and 3 also contain variables measuring the number of social media contacts respondents have, religiosity, political beliefs, the production of hateful online material, and membership in a hate group. These variables are not included in Wave 1. Wave 2 also contains variables that measure participation in protest events. These variables are not included in Wave 1 or Wave 3. Beyond containing similar variables, the three data files are unrelated to one another; each data file contains information from a unique sample. Additionally, the variables are ordered differently in each dataset. The three datasets therefore should not be linked together.

Survey Sample International (SSI) was used to collect all three waves of data. SSI was instructed to limit the sample to Internet users between the ages of 15 and 36. However, a small number of individuals in all three waves of data were beyond this range. Thus, users might want to eliminate these cases from analysis if they are focusing on youth and young adults.

These data can be used to examine a host of topics related to online hate, including factors associated with exposure to online hate, targeting by online hate, reactions to online hate, producing online hate, and engaging with online hate, among other topics.

All survey participants were ensured confidentiality before participating in the study. No identifying information was collected on the surveys, and there is no way to link individual respondents to their responses.